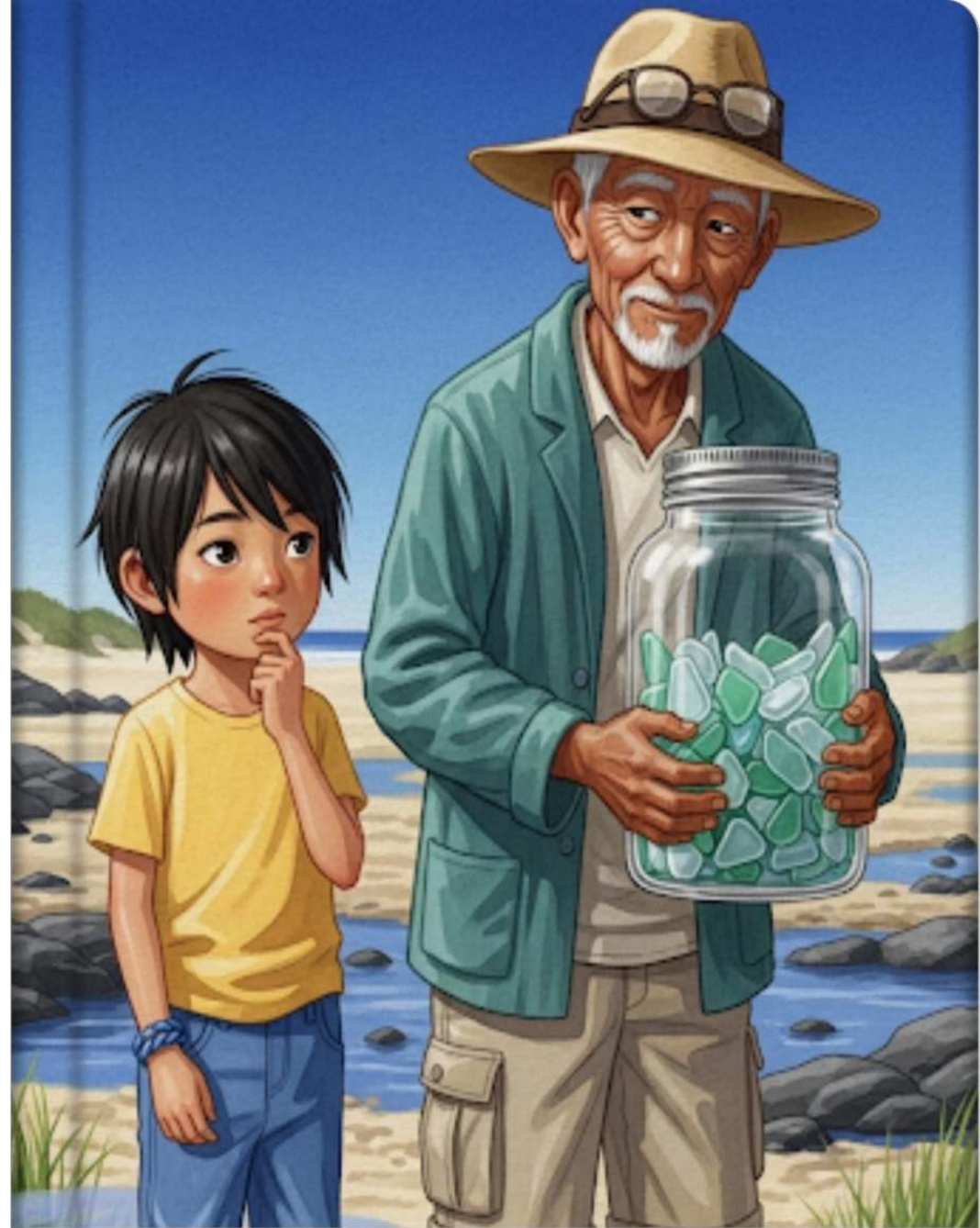




The Jar of Ocean Jewels - Sadness Edition

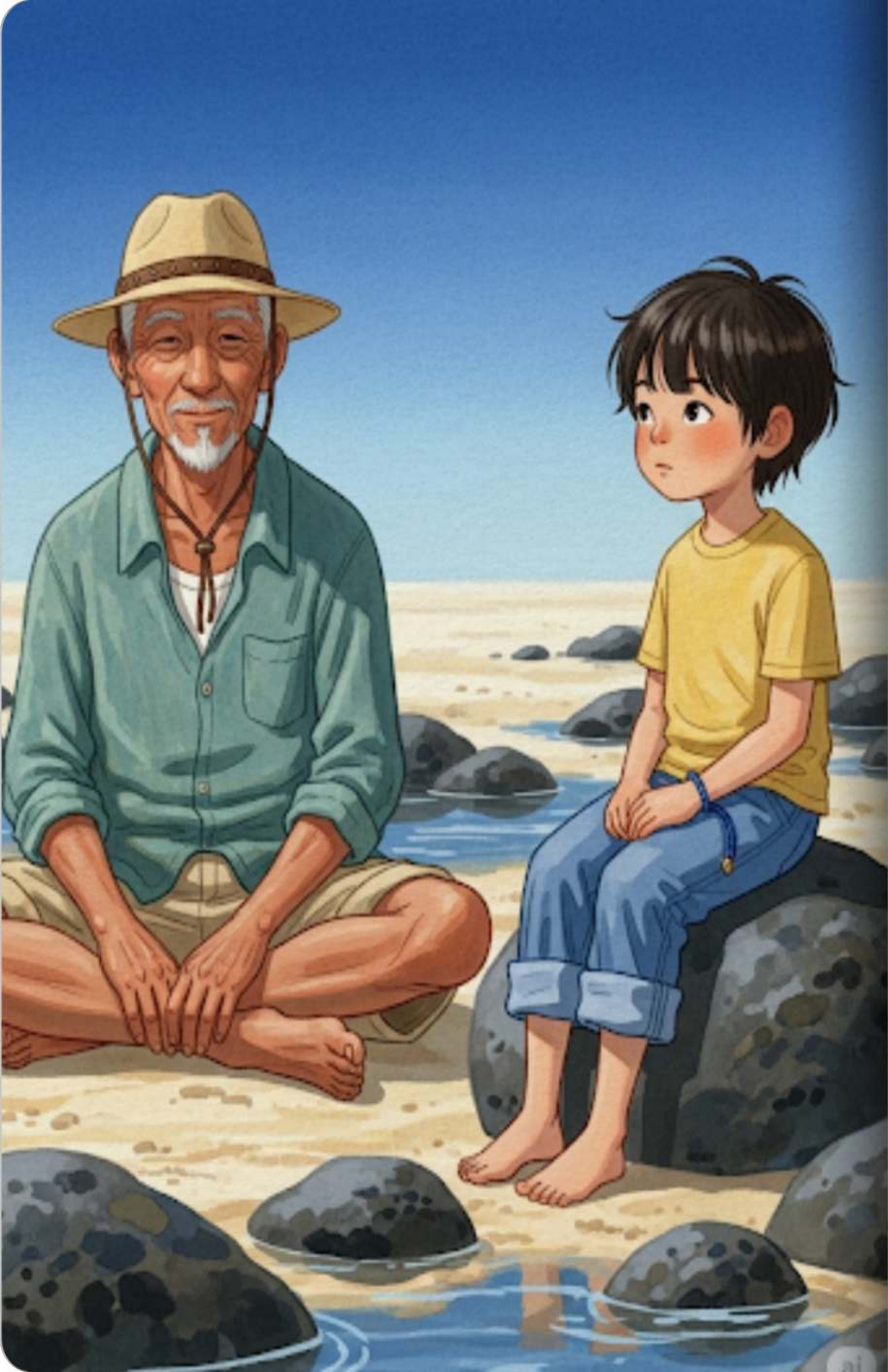
By Michael Mendez



Kai and Soren walked where the tide was pulling away from the shore. For Kai, the beach felt heavy today. He carried a "Deep Tide" in his chest—a quiet, sinking feeling that made his legs feel like they were walking through deep water. Soren looked at Kai and spoke softly, "Sadness is like a deep pool, Kai. It is quiet and dark, but that water is what helps the world grow."



The "Deep Tide" made everything feel slow and gray. Kai watched a seagull fly high above, but he didn't feel like chasing it or calling out. He sat down on a smooth, cold rock and let his shoulders slump. He felt like a rainy day was happening inside of him, even though the sun was still bright in the sky.



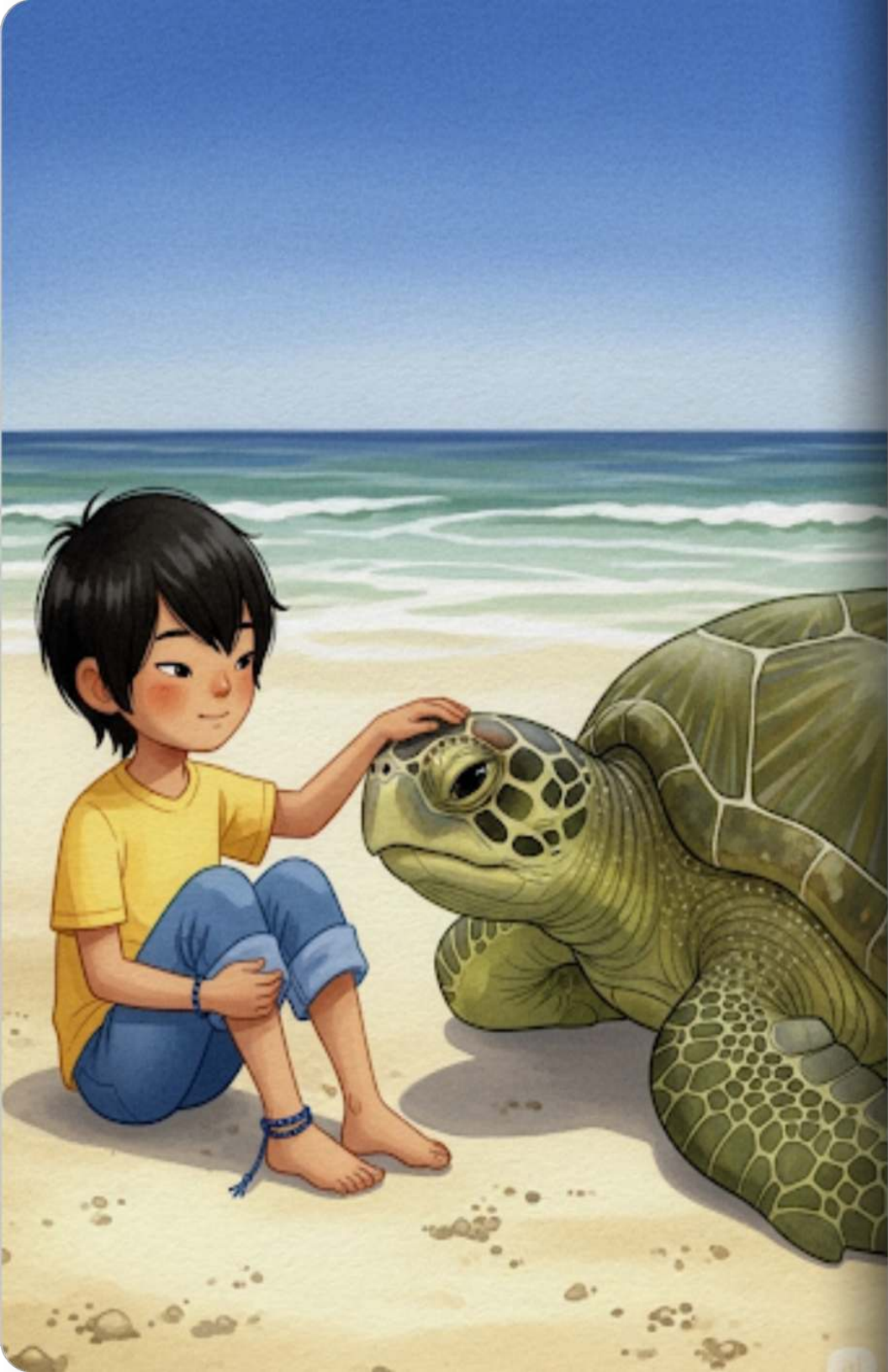
Soren sat down on the sand nearby, not saying a word at first. He didn't try to cheer Kai up or tell him to smile. He just stayed there, a steady presence in the quiet. "You don't have to chase the sun today, Kai," Soren said gently. "Sometimes we just need to sit in the mist until it clears. We can be quiet together."



Soren reached into his bag and pulled out the glass jar. He picked out a piece of sea glass that was the color of a midnight sky. "People usually look for the bright, sunny colors," Soren said, holding the dark blue glass up. "But the deep blues are special, too. They spent the longest time in the deep, being shaped by the cold currents until they became this smooth."



A large sea turtle named Malu was resting nearby on the damp sand. She wasn't swimming or splashing; she was just lying very still, her heavy shell glistening with salt. Malu looked tired, her movements slow as she blinked at the foam. Kai saw the "Deep Tide" in Malu's weary eyes and felt a sudden pull of kindness toward her.



Kai moved a little closer and sat quietly beside the turtle. He didn't try to make her move or play. "It's okay to rest, Malu," he whispered. "I feel heavy today, too." As he sat with her, Kai realized that being sad didn't mean he was broken. It just meant he was resting, just like Malu. He felt a soft connection to the world again.

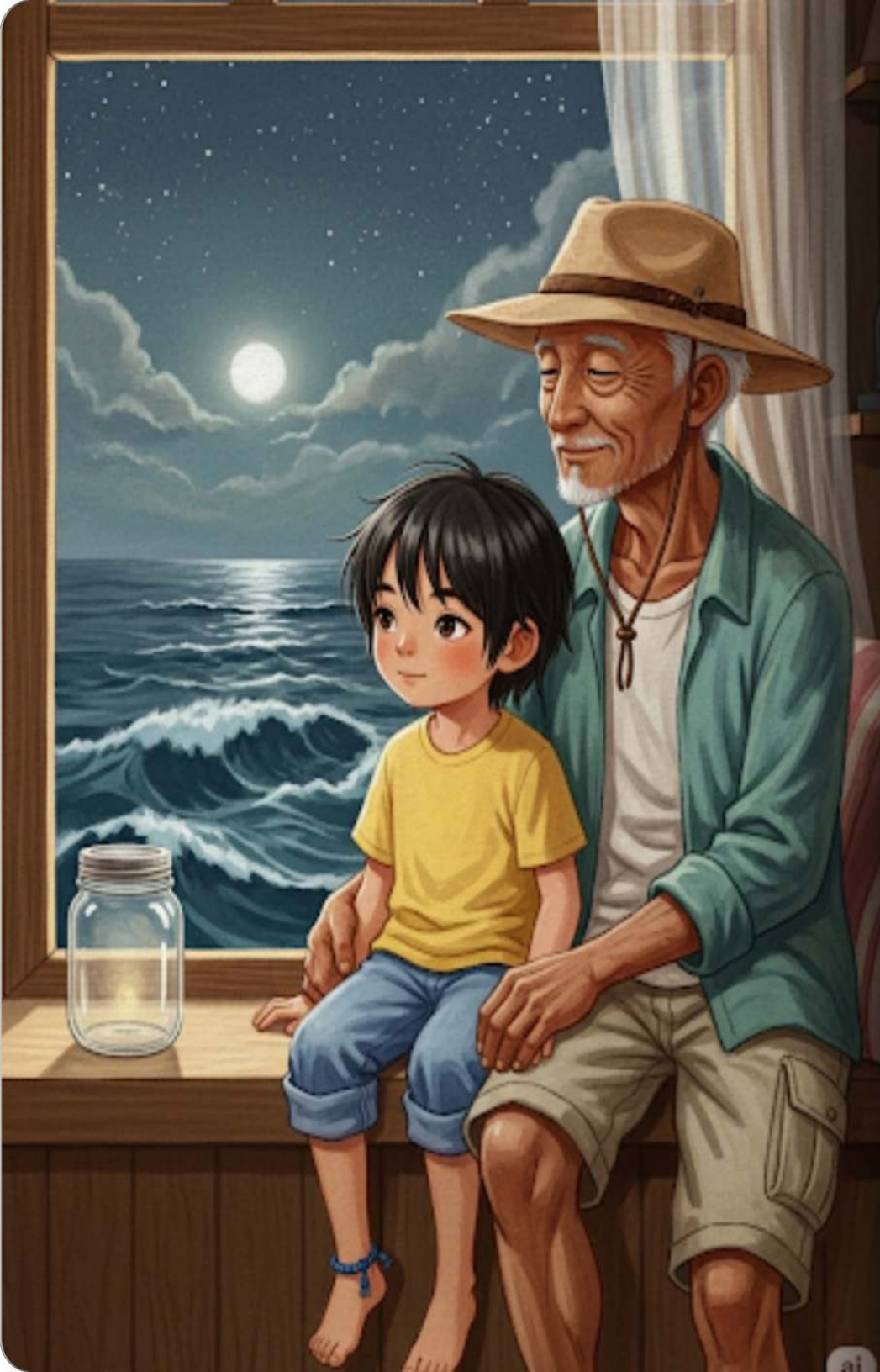


Kai looked down and found a piece of glass in the sand that was dark and cloudy, almost like a shadow. It reminded him of the heavy feeling that made him want to stay under his covers. He picked it up and held it in his palm. It wasn't sharp, but it was cool and solid. He realized that even this shadow-colored piece belonged in the jar.



"The tide always comes in, and the tide always goes out," Soren said, standing up and reaching for Kai's hand.

"Sadness is just a season of the sea. It comes to wash things clean, and then it moves on." Kai took Soren's hand, feeling the strength in his grip. He looked out at the water, which was beginning to sparkle as the clouds moved.



That evening, Kai sat by the window with Soren. He could see the distant, rhythmic pulse of the waves. He felt quiet, but it was a peaceful quiet now, like the sea after a long rain. With his friend by his side and his jar of jewels nearby, Kai knew he could handle the deep water, knowing the light would always find its way back.